

At my lowest point, I drove to a hospital emergency department at 2 am, frightened by the black cloud in my head as I lay alone in my apartment. I lived on the 17th floor, and I could see the balcony from my bedroom. After fixating on that balcony for an hour, I got out of bed, pulled jeans over my nightie and got in the car. I had to get out of the apartment.

But when I arrived in front of the hospital's sliding doors, I stood numb and static, staring into the fluorescent waiting room. I was too ashamed to go inside and admit to strangers in white coats that I wasn't coping – with buying too many shoes. It seemed ludicrous, even in my awful funk. But this was a turning point. After that night outside the hospital, feeling alone and embarrassed, I did stop. And as the damage was done, I now needed to get my finances in order.

The day, late in 2015, when I disclosed the extent of the ongoing spending problem to my parents was the day I changed my financial follies for the better. Mum and Dad are sensible with money; they're a dental nurse and a journalist who raised my sister and me in a working-class suburb. Living next to the freeway and behind a Red Rooster, where you could smell the whiff of rotting chicken carcasses if the wind blew the wrong way, I had a happy childhood free of priss and pretence.

I laid the paperwork on my parents' kitchen table and sat on the floor, head in hands, as they quietly scanned each page and made notes. I spoke (screeched and wailed) of regret, having nothing to show for years of work, and my burning desire to now buy a home. To me, buying a home would signal that I'd not just got back on track but mastered my finances, which were in severe disarray: unopened bills; late notices unanswered because I was too afraid to open the mail; no savings in the bank; escalating credit card interest; and a colossal wardrobe as evidence of the destruction.

Finally, Dad spoke over my sniffles. I think it was a swear word that broke his silence.

'Take away my money,' I told him. 'I would rather live on pocket money.' That 'pocket money' line inspired the extreme budget that my father would suggest, and the steps we would concoct together, to stem my crippling spending.

My father told me I could no longer be trusted to look after myself – not only financially, but also for my well-being. He suggested cutting off access to my wages as a tough way to start afresh.